

MD-0003: Reference-Implementation Publication Policy (Metadata Layer, Not Images)

Field	Value
ID	MD-0003
Type	MD, Maintainer Decision
Status	Accepted
Normative?	No. Governs how reference implementations are published and distributed; changes no dataset conformance requirement.
Visibility	Public (standard governance)
Proposed date	2026-07-13
Accepted date	2026-07-26
Deciders	Steering Committee / maintainers (Princeton Medical Systems)
Related	GOVERNANCE.md; publication/ZENODO-CHECKLIST-fundus-1.0.md; extensions/fundus/SPEC-FUNDUS-1.0.md

Decision

A VIDS reference implementation publishes the VIDS metadata layer and its documentation. It does not redistribute the original imaging data. The original images remain with their authoritative source repository and are referenced by a stable identifier (a DOI where one exists), unless there is a compelling reason to redistribute them.

The published metadata layer is the set of VIDS artifacts: annotation sidecars, `dataset_description.json`, participants files, quality files, README, CHANGES, LICENSE, and the governing schema copy. The source imaging is cited, not re-archived.

A "compelling reason" to redistribute is the exception, not the default. Examples include a source that has no durable public archive, or a license or consent basis that specifically favors co-deposit of the images with the metadata. When the exception is taken, the record MUST carry an explicit maintainer note stating the reason.

Rationale

VIDS's unique value is standardizing and documenting imaging datasets, not becoming another archive of the imaging data itself. Keeping images at their authoritative source keeps the standard focused on that value, avoids duplicating large binary archives, and keeps attribution and licensing clean: the metadata layer is published under the VIDS-consistent license (CC BY 4.0) and references the source under the source's own terms, rather than mixing the two in one deposit. It is consistent with the project architecture, in which VIDS is a metadata and annotation layer over source imaging, and it makes future reference implementations simpler and more consistent to assemble.

Consequences

- The Fundus 1.0 IDRiD reference implementation is metadata-only. It does not redistribute the IDRiD fundus images; it references them by the source DOI 10.21227/H25W98 (CC BY 4.0). This resolves the high-priority open item in the Zenodo publication checklist.
- The record description, attribution wording, licensing presentation, and citation for that deposit are finalized as a metadata layer over a cited source.
- Future extensions and reference implementations adopt the same default without re-deciding it per dataset.
- Where the redistribution exception is invoked, an explicit maintainer note is required in the record.

Scope note

This is a publication and distribution policy, not a dataset conformance rule. A dataset that does happen to include images is not non-conformant to VIDS; conformance is judged against the specification and schema, not against this policy. MD-0003 governs what Princeton Medical Systems publishes as VIDS reference implementations.

Sign-off

Maintainer	Decision	Approval date
Dr. Joan S. Muthu	Approved	2026-07-26
John Shalen R.	Approved	2026-07-26

Approval evidence: MD-0003-ApprovalEvidence-2026-07-26.pdf

Change log

Date	Change
2026-07-13	Initial draft (Proposed).
2026-07-26	Accepted following approval by Joan S. Muthu and John Shalen R.

MD-0003 is a governance-process decision. It is non-normative with respect to dataset conformance.